

Balancing dreams and parental aspirations: A dilemma for students

In a society deeply **rooted** in tradition and shaped by economic **uncertainty**, parents **often tread** cautiously when guiding their children's career paths

We **tend to** be overcautious when we guide our children in their professional choices. I realised this only after I had **cajoled** my children into studying sciences till their class 12. My **rationale** was that they could always switch to any other course for graduation, but the reverse was not possible. They are now happily **pursuing** their non-science professions, often **ribbing** me about how much better they could have done in their Board examinations had I not **insisted**. **Many parents** from my social circle still **struggle** to resolve the **conundrum**.

A senior colleague faced such a dilemma for his daughter two **decades** back. My daughters were by now happily pursuing their dreams. I freely **dispensed** my **wisdom** to let the young lady pursue whatever she wanted. He was **contemplative** for some time before agreeing. He remembered his school friend, the son of a famous medical doctor.

The friend was pushed into a medical college sometime in the late sixties. He quit after a couple of years, joined a course in liberal arts, and was a **contented** leading artist. I was born a few years after independence. I believe our parents were excited about freedom but were equally **apprehensive** about the future for the next generation.

They opted for the more secure government jobs for us through engineering or medical studies. **Children** from families who had already seen enough government jobs through second-generation elders **started** moving to other options in the nineties. The **liberalisation** of the Indian economy **opened** professional choices **hitherto** unknown to children and parents alike. But it was still not the same across the entire **spectrum**.

A junior colleague **sought** my advice regarding his son's admission to an engineering course. The child had not performed well in the competitive examinations.

The **fee** charged by the available **lower-rung** colleges **was** **exorbitant**, **necessitating** the father to take a loan. It was tragic as he came to me after five years, a year after the young man had completed his graduation and had been unable to secure a job, requesting if I could arrange a job even at a **measly** monthly salary. I **witnessed** several similar cases and **wondered** about the strange **phenomenon** even half a century after independence when several better-paying career options were available.

An improved economy has **resulted in** a continuous upward movement of people financially from the below-poverty line to the lower class to the lower-middle-class to the middle-middle-class, and so on. However, an increasing population also ensures a part of the population remains in the lower financial **strata**. These parents are insecure about the future leading them towards the **perceived** safer

educational courses for children to pursue. We read about senior leaders **exhorting** young people to become job providers instead of job seekers.

Not many talk about the ways to achieve this or the alternate career options. Engineering and medical colleges keep **mushrooming** without the government and the leaders pausing to **reflect upon** the **implications** of unplanned growth. This will continue for a few more generations till the population **stabilizes**. I narrate experiences from my life when interacting with the young in college.

I tell them to pursue their dreams. **A few** of them **invariably ask** me whether to follow the courses that their parents have chosen for them or if they should follow their dreams. It is a difficult question to answer. I **draw upon** my life when I respond, "Follow your parents today, they only want the best for you. But do not let your dreams die. Life gives enough opportunities for you to pursue your dreams – if not today, certainly sometime in the future."

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

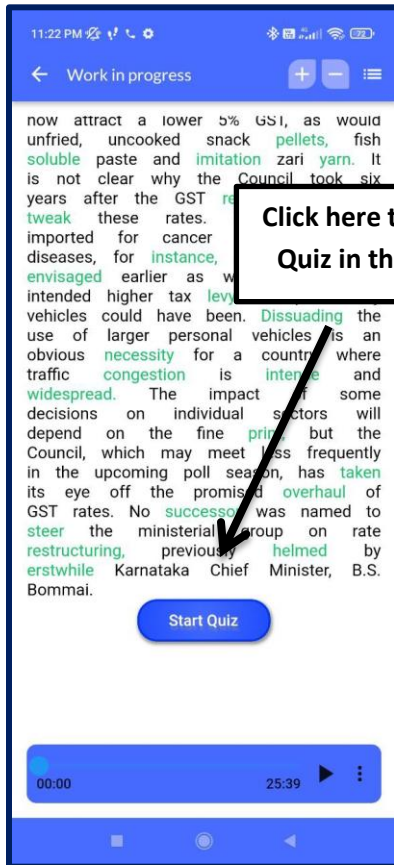
1. **Dilemma** (noun) – Predicament, quandary, impasse, perplexity, bind दुविधा
2. **Root** (in) (verb) – Embed, instill, implant, ingrain, fix जड़ें जमाना
3. **Uncertainty** (noun) – Ambiguity, doubt, indecision, unpredictability, vagueness अनिश्चितता
4. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, repeatedly, regularly, commonly, habitually अक्सर
5. **Tread** (verb) – Walk, step, pace, march, trample चलना
6. **Tend** (to) (verb) – Incline, lean, favor, gravitate, be disposed झुकाव रखना
7. **Cajole** (verb) – Persuade, coax, wheedle, sweet-talk, entice मनाना
8. **Rationale** (noun) – Reasoning, justification, basis, explanation, logic तर्क
9. **Pursue** (verb) – Chase, follow, seek, strive for, endeavour पीछा करना
10. **Rib** (verb) – Tease, mock, jest, chaff, poke fun at मज़ाक करना
11. **Insist** (verb) – Demand, assert, press, emphasize, persist जोर देना
12. **Conundrum** (noun) – Puzzle, enigma, riddle, quandary, mystery पहेली
13. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
14. **Dispense** (verb) – Distribute, allocate, provide, administer, deliver वितरित करना
15. **Wisdom** (noun) – Knowledge, insight, understanding, intelligence, prudence बुद्धिमानी
16. **Contemplative** (adjective) – Reflective, thoughtful, meditative, introspective, pensive विचारशील
17. **Contented** (adjective) – Satisfied, pleased, happy, fulfilled, gratified संतुष्ट
18. **Apprehensive** (adjective) – Anxious, uneasy, fearful, nervous, worried चिंतित
19. **Liberalisation** (noun) – Deregulation, relaxation, modernization, emancipation, freedom उदारीकरण
20. **Hitherto** (adverb) – Previously, earlier, formerly, until now, so far अब तक
21. **Spectrum** (noun) – Range, gamut, scope, extent, array विस्तार
22. **Seek** (verb) – Search, pursue, request, strive, look for खोजना
23. **Lower-rung** (adjective) – Low-tier, subordinate, inferior, bottom-level, basic निचले स्तर का
24. **Exorbitant** (adjective) – Excessive, overpriced, inflated, steep, outrageous अत्यधिक

25. **Necessitate** (verb) – Require, demand, compel, mandate, oblige आवश्यक बनाना
26. **Measly** (adverb) – Paltry, insignificant, meager, pitiful, trivial तुच्छ; छोटा
27. **Witness** (verb) – Observe, see, experience, perceive, testify देखना
28. **Wonder** (verb) – Question, ponder, marvel, contemplate, reflect आश्चर्य करना
29. **Phenomenon** (noun) – Event, occurrence, happening, fact, anomal घटना
30. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – Lead to, cause, bring about, produce, culminate in परिणामस्वरूप होना
31. **Strata** (noun) – Layers, levels, tiers, classes, ranks स्तर
32. **Perceived** (adjective) – Seen, observed, understood, recognized, sensed माना जाता
33. **Exhort** (verb) – Urge, encourage, implore, press, advocate प्रोत्साहित करना
34. **Mushroom** (verb) – Expand, proliferate, grow rapidly, sprout, burgeon तेजी से बढ़ना
35. **Reflect** (on) (verb) – Think, ponder, contemplate, consider, deliberate विचार करना
36. **Implication** (noun) – Consequence, inference, suggestion, meaning, effect निहितार्थ
37. **Stabilize** (verb) – Steady, secure, balance, fix, anchor स्थिर करना
38. **Invariably** (adverb) – Always, consistently, constantly, unfailingly, inevitably लगभग हमेशा
39. **Draw upon** (phrasal verb) – Utilize, use, access, rely on, apply लाभ उठाना

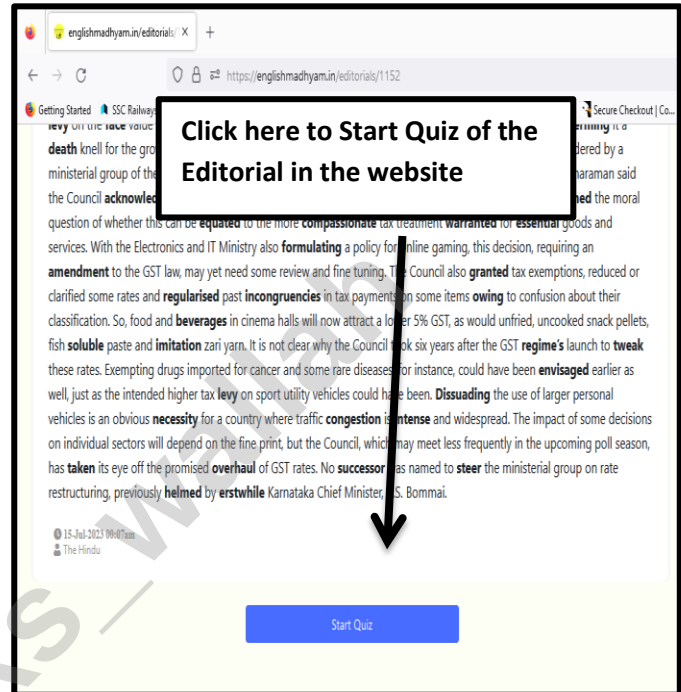
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Parental Overcaution:** Parents often steer their children toward secure career paths like science, engineering, or medicine, believing these offer stability and opportunities.
2. **Personal Reflection:** The author shares their experience of encouraging their children to study science until class 12, only to later realize they flourished in non-science fields.
3. **Societal Tradition:** Post-independence parents favored government jobs, engineering, or medicine, driven by apprehension about the future and the desire for economic stability.
4. **Economic Liberalization:** The 1990s brought more career choices due to India's economic reforms, but traditional preferences persisted among many families.
5. **Examples of Misdirected Choices:** Cases of students forced into courses they were unsuited for, leading to unemployment or dissatisfaction, highlight the risks of ignoring personal interests.
6. **Financial Pressures:** High costs of education in less reputed colleges can lead to burdensome loans, especially for families pursuing perceived "safe" careers for their children.
7. **Economic Mobility:** While economic growth has uplifted many families, financial insecurity among lower-income groups sustains cautious parental choices.
8. **Mushrooming Institutions:** Unchecked growth of engineering and medical colleges exacerbates the issue, producing graduates without corresponding job opportunities.
9. **Job Provider vs. Job Seeker:** Senior leaders urge youth to become entrepreneurs but provide little guidance or support for alternate career paths.
10. **Generational Shift:** Economic and societal factors suggest a gradual shift towards more diversified career preferences as population growth stabilizes.
11. **Student Queries:** Young individuals often seek advice on whether to prioritize their dreams or follow parental expectations.
12. **Advice to Students:** The author advises students to respect parental wishes while keeping their dreams alive, as life often presents opportunities to pursue passions later.
13. **Balanced Perspective:** Parental guidance stems from a place of care, but it must evolve to recognize the broader spectrum of viable careers in a changing world.
14. **Need for Awareness:** Parents and leaders should better understand the implications of forcing conventional career paths, especially when viable alternatives exist.
15. **Empowering Youth:** Encouraging students to align their aspirations with pragmatic goals ensures both personal fulfillment and societal progress.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



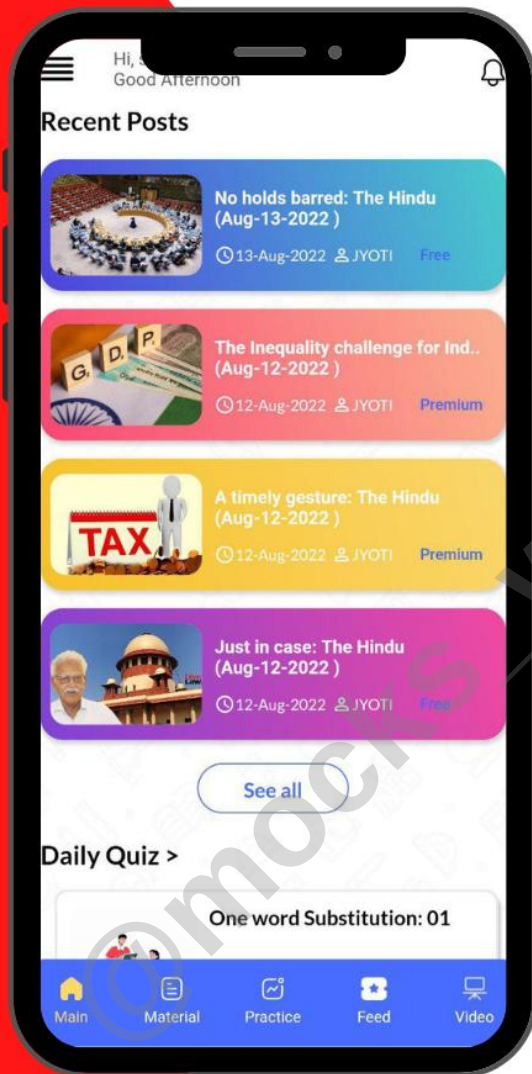
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